CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 05

WEEK OF 7 DECEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



HOSPITALITY

Ready for Martyn's Law.

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down and tell everyone on site, fast. A practical playbook for hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, written for the busiest weeks of the year.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical playbook for hotels, pubs, bars, restaurants and venues: what Martyn's Law will require, how every shift protects guests and staff on the worst night, and how to be ready before the festive season peaks.

Foreword 03

Introduction 04

01 Know the duty 06

02 On the night 11

03 Ready for December 21

04 Rehearse and review 27

Readiness assessment and buyer's guide 36

Sources 38

FOREWORD

In a busy bar or hotel, the first minutes belong to the people on shift.

On the night of the London Bridge and Borough Market attack in June 2017, the attackers moved through a restaurant courtyard, bars and a restaurant on Stoney Street. The Chief Coroner found that all eight people who died did so within 15 minutes of the attack beginning.[1] In the City Room at Manchester Arena a few weeks earlier, a concern raised by a member of the public did not reach anyone who could act on it, partly because a radio channel was busy.[2]

Martyn's Law, the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, is named after Martyn Hett, one of the 22 people killed at Manchester Arena.[2,3] It received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025, and the Security Industry Authority expects it to come into force in spring 2027.[3,4] Pubs, bars, restaurants, cafés, hotels and nightclubs where 200 or more people can be expected at the same time will need procedures to evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate with everyone on site.[4,5,6]

This playbook is for the people who will make that work on a Saturday night in December: owners, general managers, duty managers, security leads and operations teams. It covers the law as enacted, the roles each shift needs, how to reach guests and staff in minutes, the other emergencies that are far more likely, and a dated plan. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things protect people on the worst night.

Hospitality venues are busy, noisy, open late and staffed by people on different shifts, many of them new. The venues that cope best are not the ones with the thickest plan. They are the ones where every shift knows who decides, what to do and how to tell everyone fast.

One person decides

Every shift has a named duty manager who can declare an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown without waiting for permission, and everyone knows who that is tonight.

Everyone hears it at once

A code phrase, a radio call and an alert to every phone, so the kitchen, the bedrooms and the smoking area hear the same instruction within a minute.

Plans people actually know

Short procedures, briefed at induction and walked through on the late shift, not a binder in the office that nobody has opened.

A plan nobody on shift knows is not a plan.

The Manchester Arena Inquiry found that on the night, plans "were not known by everyone who should have known about them".[7] Martyn's Law asks hospitality to close that gap before the law starts, not after.

PART 01

Know the duty.

What the Act requires of hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, the four procedures, a severity scale every shift can use and how incidents escalate.

01 What the law says, exactly

02 Four procedures for every venue

03 A hospitality severity ladder

04 Escalation from the shift to head office

KNOW THE DUTY

What Martyn's Law asks of hospitality

> **Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday.**

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. The Home Office expects an implementation period of at least 24 months, and there is no legal requirement to comply until the duties come into force.[4] The SIA, which will regulate the Act, says it expects the Act to come into force in spring 2027 and will confirm the exact date ahead of time.[3]

The Act covers premises wholly or mainly used for purposes listed in Schedule 1. Statutory guidance says the "food and drink" use "includes bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés and food halls"; "hotels etc" also covers hostels and holiday parks; and nightclubs fall under entertainment and leisure.[6]

Premises are in the standard tier where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected to be present at the same time from time to time, and in the enhanced tier at 800 or more.[4] Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday: a Christmas party, a New Year's Eve ticketed event or a wedding in the function suite.

Standard tier premises must notify the SIA and have, so far as is reasonably practicable, appropriate public protection procedures for evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.[4,5] The Home Office says these are simple, low-cost steps that do not require physical alterations or new equipment.[4]

Enhanced tier premises must also have public protection measures covering monitoring, movement, physical safety and security, and the security of information; document compliance and give it to the SIA; and, where the responsible person is an organisation, designate a senior individual.[8]

Penalties reach £10,000 for standard duty premises, and £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue for enhanced duty premises.[9] Existing premises will have three months from commencement to notify the SIA, and changes must be notified within 28 days.[10]

FOUR PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

The Act's four public protection procedures, as the Home Office defines them, and what each means in a hotel, bar or restaurant.[5]

Evacuation

"Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises." Know every exit, including through the kitchen, and where guests go once they are out.[5]

Invacuation

"Moving people away from danger to a place within the premises." A function room, back corridor or cellar away from glass and the main doors.[5]

Lockdown

"Securing the premises to prevent individuals entering or leaving." Who locks which door, who drops the shutters, how fast, and on every shift.[5]

Communication

"Ensuring information is provided to individuals at the premises." Staff, guests, bedrooms, terraces, toilets, contractors and the next shift.[5]

The Home Office's own example is a 400-seat restaurant: two evacuation routes, nominated staff who lock doors and close shutters on the shift manager's instruction, and a short briefing for every new starter at induction.[5]

SEVERITY

A hospitality severity ladder for every shift

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later. The duty manager can declare any level.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An attack or credible threat at or next to the venue. A fire with people unaccounted for. A crowd crush or several casualties.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Everyone on site, the on-call general manager, the head office crisis team and security leads. 999 first.

Code phrase · radio · PA · SMS · voice

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

A full evacuation on a busy night. A suspicious item. A serious assault or suspected spiking needing hospital. Power lost in service. Booking or payment systems down across sites.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, area or operations manager, IT or facilities on call.

Radio · SMS · push · escalate after 10 min

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

One site's tills or booking system failing. A guest collapse. An aggressive group removed. People trapped in a lift.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk.

Radio · push · email

SEV 4

Minor

TRIGGERS

Suspicious behaviour reported and resolved. A near miss. A single device fault. Verbal abuse logged.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, recorded for the weekly review and trend reporting.

App · email

ESCALATION

How an incident climbs from the shift to head office

Illustrative timings, to be set by each operator. Each level follows the severity ladder, and escalating never takes away the duty manager's authority to act at once on site.

LEVEL 1 **On-shift report**	TRIGGER Suspicious behaviour, an unattended bag, a near miss or a guest unwell. Severity 4.	WHO IS ALERTED The duty manager, by radio, the code phrase or a one-touch alert with location.	WHO DECIDES Duty manager, after a quick check with the person who reported it.

↓ ESCALATE IF THE ITEM CANNOT BE CLEARED WITHIN 5 MINUTES OR ANYONE IS AT RISK

LEVEL 2 **Venue incident**	TRIGGER A guest collapse, an aggressive group, a lift entrapment or one site's tills down. Severity 3.	WHO IS ALERTED Every member of staff on shift, and the on-call general manager.	WHO DECIDES Duty manager. The general manager is informed, not asked for permission.

↓ ESCALATE IF THE VENUE EVACUATES, INVACUATES OR LOCKS DOWN, OR 999 IS CALLED FOR A THREAT

LEVEL 3 **Major venue incident**	TRIGGER Full evacuation, lockdown, a suspicious item or a serious assault. Severity 2.	WHO IS ALERTED On-call general manager, operations manager, off-duty staff and the next shift.	WHO DECIDES Duty manager on site. Operations manager decides on closing and the next shift.

↓ ESCALATE IF ANOTHER VENUE IS AFFECTED, ANYONE IS SERIOUSLY HURT, OR MEDIA ARRIVE

LEVEL 4 **Group crisis**	TRIGGER An attack or credible threat, several venues affected, or a group-wide system outage. Severity 1.	WHO IS ALERTED Head office crisis team, every duty manager nearby, security lead and communications.	WHO DECIDES Head office incident lead for closures, statements and bookings; duty managers for safety on site.

Silence is a trigger too. If the person alerted at any level has not acknowledged within 5 minutes, the alert moves automatically to the next named person, and the gap is recorded for the review.

PART 02

On the night.

The first hour of the worst night, the roles every shift needs, how to reach everyone, and the emergencies that are far more likely.

01 The first hour, and across three venues

02 Roles and the shift responsibility matrix

03 Reaching staff and guests fast

04 Other emergencies and messages ready to send

05 Tracking what is still outstanding

THE FIRST HOUR

Saturday, 22:15: an attack outside

Illustrative: a city-centre hotel with a bar and restaurant, around 550 people on site. Police instructions always come first.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Door team sees people running from the street** Shouts of a knife attack nearby. The door supervisor radios the code phrase to the duty manager.	DOOR SUPERVISOR
T+00:01	**Lockdown and invacuation declared** Doors locked, shutters down, music off. Guests moved away from glass to the function room.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:02	**999 called, log started** What, where, which direction, how many on site. Every decision from now is logged with a time.	RECEPTION
T+00:03	**Every member of staff alerted** Code phrase on the PA, radio and an alert to every phone. Staff reply when their area is safe, and replies are tracked by area.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:06	**Guests in bedrooms told to stay put** Room phones and text: stay in your room, lock the door, keep away from windows.	NIGHT MANAGER
T+00:12	**Everyone accounted for, escalated** This is where it often goes wrong: smokers, agency staff and anyone outside. Chase every gap by name. On-call general manager and head office alerted.	SHIFT MANAGERS
T+01:00	**Police briefed, people cared for** Floor plans and numbers to police. Guests and staff stay inside until police advise otherwise. Open actions move to a tracker with owners.	GENERAL MANAGER

ACROSS VENUES

One night, three venues and head office

Illustrative: a group with a hotel, a bar on the same street and a restaurant 1 km away. Red cards show where a multi-venue response breaks down; police instructions always come first.

	22:15	22:17	22:20	22:30	22:45	23:30
Hotel (on scene)	Door team radios the code phrase ◆ Duty manager declares lockdown	999 called; alert raised with location	Staff replies tracked area by area	Three staff unaccounted for, chased by name	Guests in bedrooms told to stay put	Police briefed with floor plans and numbers
Bar, same street	! Shouting outside; staff unsure who decides	◆ Duty manager locks doors and invacuates	! Two agency staff missing from alert list		Agency staff found; head count complete	
Restaurant, 1 km away			! Staff first hear of it on social media	Guests held inside, away from the cordon	! Guests pushing to leave before police advice	◆ Guests released only on police advice
On-call operations manager		Alerted; warns every nearby venue		◆ Decides restaurant takes no new guests	Off-duty staff told not to travel in	Open actions handed to named owners
Head office crisis team			Crisis team activated, roles assigned	Live view of venues, replies and gaps	◆ Decides to close all city venues tonight	Holding statement out; bookings contacted

Action · Decision · Where it goes wrong · Monitored

> Three things decide how this night goes: every venue hears from the group, not from social media; every person on shift, agency staff included, is on the alert list; and each decision has one named owner who does not wait for someone more senior.

ROLES

Who does what, on every shift

Name the people at the start of each shift. There is no statutory training requirement, but staff with a role in the procedures must know them and what they have to do.[5]

01 Duty manager: decides and declares

Has authority to call evacuation, invacuation or lockdown at once, and to call 999. Does not wait for head office.

02 Door and security team: first eyes

Spot and report early, lock doors, stop people entering, and give police clear information on arrival.

03 Bar and floor staff: move the room

Each person owns a section: move guests from glass and doors, sweep toilets and terraces, and report when clear.

04 Reception or night manager: the hotel

Calls 999, reaches guests in bedrooms and holds the guest list and today's function bookings.

05 Kitchen and back of house: the rear

Secure the back doors and delivery yard, cut gas if instructed, and know which rooms can be used as safe areas.

06 Communicator: who has heard

Sends the alert, tracks who has replied and chases the rest, and logs who was told what and when.

SHIFT MATRIX

Shift responsibility matrix

Who does what in a lockdown, invacuation or evacuation, by shift role. Write tonight's names against each column at the start of the shift.

ACTIVITY	DUTY MANAGER	SUPERVISOR	DOOR AND SECURITY	FRONT OF HOUSE	KITCHEN	HEAD OFFICE
Spot and report a threat by code phrase or one-touch alert	A	R	R	R	R	·
Declare evacuation, invacuation or lockdown	A	I	C	I	I	I
Call 999 and start the timed incident log	A	R	I	R	·	I
Lock front doors and stop people entering	A	I	R	C	·	·
Secure rear doors, the delivery yard and gas	A	I	·	·	R	·
Move guests from glass and doors to the safe area	A	R	C	R	I	·
Reach guests in bedrooms, toilets and terraces	A	R	·	R	·	·
Alert all staff, track replies and chase the silent	A	R	I	I	I	I
Head count of staff and guests by area	A	R	R	R	R	I
Brief police on arrival with plans and numbers	A	C	R	C	·	I
Media, social media and tomorrow's bookings	C	·	·	I	·	A

R Responsible: does the work · A Accountable: owns the decision · C Consulted · I Informed

> In a smaller venue one person may hold several columns. What matters is that every row has a name tonight, and that the duty manager never waits for head office to act on safety.

COMMUNICATION

Reaching guests and staff in minutes

Noise, music, bedrooms, outdoor areas and staff on breaks make hospitality hard to reach. Use more than one route, and confirm who has heard.

A code phrase everyone knows

A neutral phrase on the PA or radio that tells staff what is happening without alarming guests. Change it if it leaks.

Stop the music, light the room

Music off and house lights up so announcements can be heard, unless lockdown means lights off on police advice.

An alert to every phone

One message to staff on duty by SMS, push and voice, with a reply to confirm. Chase anyone who does not answer.

Guests you cannot see

Bedrooms, toilets, terraces, smoking areas and private dining rooms each need a named person or route.

People off site

The next shift, off-duty staff and families. Tell them not to come in, and keep updates on a schedule. Counter Terrorism Policing's public advice is RUN, HIDE, TELL.[11]

At Manchester Arena, a steward without a radio passed on a concern; a colleague with one tried to report it but someone else was talking, and it went no further.[2] Never rely on a single channel.

GUEST COMMUNICATION

Talking to guests: what to consider

Guests do not know your code phrases, your layout or your staff. Plan how each group is reached, and agree what nobody says.

GUESTS	HOW TO REACH THEM	WHAT TO SAY, AND WHAT TO AVOID
In bars, restaurants and function rooms	Music off, lights up. Staff in each section give the same short instruction face to face.	Say what to do, not why: "Please come with me to the back room now." Do not shout words that cause panic.
In bedrooms	Room phone, a text to the mobile given at booking, and door knocks only where it is safe.	"Stay in your room, lock the door, keep away from windows. Next update by [time]."
Who do not speak English	Short translated lines in the languages your guests most often speak, plus showing the way.	Short sentences and plain words. No idioms, and never the staff code phrase.
Who need help to move or to hear an alarm	Ask at booking and check-in; name a member of staff for each guest on the shift.	Tell them who is coming, where to wait and how they will be told it is safe.
Outside: terraces, smoking areas, queues	Bring them in or move them away, as the duty manager decides. In lockdown the door team controls entry.	"Come inside now" or "Move away from the building", with a clear direction.
Everyone, at every stage	One approved message, repeated, with a time for the next update.	Never guess the cause or casualties, name anyone involved or post on social media. Media get the holding line.

OTHER EMERGENCIES

The emergencies that are far more likely

Terrorism is rare. Fire, medical emergencies, spiking, power and system failures are not. The same roles and alerts handle them all.

EMERGENCY	FIRST ACTION ON SITE	FIRST ACTION FOR MANAGERS
Fire alarm in a full venue	Evacuate by the plan. Sweep sections and bedrooms. Do not let guests collect coats or go back in.	Account for staff and guests from the booking and room lists. Meet the fire service with the plan.
Medical emergency	Call 999, send for the defibrillator and a first aider, clear space and send someone to guide the ambulance.	Look after witnesses and staff, record what happened and check first aid cover for the rest of the night.
Suspected spiking	Stay with the person, get help and call police or an ambulance if needed. Keep the drink if you can.	Report it, keep CCTV and brief door staff. Police received 6,732 reports in a year to April 2023.[12]
Power failure	Emergency lighting check, stop cooking, keep exits clear, and decide quickly whether to evacuate.	Call the supplier or facilities, plan for lifts, fridges, tills and door locks, and tell arriving guests.
Booking or payment systems down	Switch to the paper booking list and offline or cash procedure. Do not keep restarting terminals.	Find out whether it is an outage or an attack, and tell sites what still works. A 2022 cyber incident disrupted IHG's booking channels.[13]
Violence or disorder	Make safe, call 999 if anyone is in danger, and do not detain. Staff safety first.	Support the staff involved, keep CCTV and review staffing for the next nights.

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and calm. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always say when the next update will come.

SMS · STAFF ON DUTY

139 chars

> LOCKDOWN at [venue]. Move guests away from doors and glass to [area]. Doors stay locked. Do not go outside. Reply 1 when your area is safe.

Under 160 characters, so it arrives as one message.

SMS · HOTEL GUESTS

144 chars

> [Hotel]: police are dealing with an incident nearby. Please stay in your room, lock the door and keep away from windows. Next update by [22:45].

Only to guests who have given a mobile number.

SMS · OFF-DUTY AND NEXT SHIFT

131 chars

> [Venue] is closed tonight due to an incident nearby. Do not travel in. Everyone on site is being looked after. Next update [08:00].

EMAIL · GUESTS WITH BOOKINGS

> Because of an incident near [venue], we are closed this evening. Please do not travel to us. Your booking will be [moved or refunded] and we will contact you by [time].

Send from the booking system so it reaches tonight's and tomorrow's bookings.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND BOOKING PLATFORMS

> Our booking and payment systems are offline while we investigate. Deliveries continue as booked. Do not act on any request to change bank details; call [known number].

Attackers often follow an outage with fake payment requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an incident near [venue] this evening. Our priority is the safety of our guests and team, and we are following police advice. We will share more when we can.

OUTSTANDING ACTIONS

Sunday, 11:00: what is still open

Illustrative, the morning after the three-venue incident. Every action has one owner, a time and a way of checking it is done, so nothing depends on memory.

ACTION	OWNER	DUE	STATUS	HOW IT IS CHECKED
Account for every member of staff at all three venues	Operations manager	Sat 22:45	DONE	Replies on the alert, gaps called by name
Updated holding statement agreed	Head office comms	Sun 09:00	DONE	Approved version saved in the log
Keep CCTV from all three venues for police	Security lead	Sun 09:00	IN PROGRESS	Police reference recorded in the log
Contact guests booked today at closed venues	Reservations	Sun 10:00	OVERDUE	Send report from the booking system
Add the two missing agency staff to alert lists	Operations manager	Sun 10:00	OVERDUE	Test alert, reply received
Welfare call to staff who saw the incident	General manager	Sun 12:00	IN PROGRESS	Named list, each call logged
Brief the next shift before any reopening	Duty managers	Sun 14:00	OPEN	Signed shift briefing record
Decide whether the hotel bar reopens tonight	Head office incident lead	Sun 15:00	BLOCKED	Waiting for police to lift the cordon
Notify the insurer and keep the timeline	Finance	Mon 12:00	OPEN	Insurer reference in the log

> Review the board at a fixed time, not when someone remembers. Overdue and blocked actions go to the head office incident lead, and the board becomes the starting point for the post-incident review.

PART 03

Ready for December.

What to do before the first Christmas party, two templates for every shift, a dated plan and a checklist.

01 Festive season readiness

02 Shift briefing record

03 Area sweep and head count log

04 Week, month, quarter

05 Checklist

FESTIVE READINESS

Six steps before the first Christmas party

The weeks to New Year bring the biggest crowds, the most new staff and the longest nights. Finish these now.

01 Count your peak nights

Work out how many people, including staff, can reasonably be expected on your busiest nights, function rooms and terraces included. It decides your tier.[4,6]

02 Name the duty manager for every night

Publish who decides on each shift until 2 January, with an on-call general manager behind them.

03 Brief every seasonal starter

A short induction on the four procedures and their role, as in the Home Office restaurant example.[5]

04 Walk through a lockdown

Ten minutes with the late shift: which doors lock, where guests go, who checks the toilets and terrace.

05 Load every contact, including agency staff

Mobile numbers for everyone on the rota, tested with a short alert that asks for a reply.

06 Plan for the outage

Paper booking lists, an offline payment or cash procedure and a known number for every supplier.

TEMPLATE

Shift safety briefing record

Complete at the start of every shift, in two minutes, and keep it with the incident log. Agency and new staff sign the same record as everyone else.

DATE AND SHIFT	DUTY MANAGER (DECIDES)	CODE PHRASE BRIEFED	SAFE AREA AND LOCKDOWN DOORS	NEW OR AGENCY STAFF BRIEFED	TEST ALERT REPLIES	SIGNED
Sat 20 Dec, late	*[Name], on-call GM [name]*	*Yes, all sections*	*Function room; front, side, yard doors*	*3 agency, named, briefed*	*41 of 42, 1 chased*	*[Initials]*

Illustrative template. If the test alert does not reach everyone on the rota, fix the contact list before service starts, not after the incident.

TEMPLATE

Area sweep and head count log

Used during an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown. Each area has one named person who sweeps it, counts who is there and reports back to the duty manager.

AREA	SWEPT BY	TIME CLEAR	GUESTS IN AREA	STAFF IN AREA	NEEDS HELP OR MISSING	REPORTED TO AND TIME
Terrace and smoking area	*[Name], floor*	*22:19*	*14*	*2*	*1 guest in wheelchair, staff with her*	*Duty manager 22:20*

Illustrative template. List every area before the shift starts: bars, toilets, terraces, function rooms, kitchen, cellar, bedrooms by floor. An area with no name is an area nobody checks.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Name a duty manager for every night to New Year. Brief the four procedures and the code phrase at every shift start.	General manager
This week	Load every staff mobile, including agency and seasonal staff, and test an alert that asks for a reply.	Operations manager
This month	Count peak numbers for every site and room. Decide your likely tier and who the responsible person is.	Head of security, with legal
This month	Write one page per site: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication. Walk through lockdown on a late shift.	General manager
This quarter	Prepare for SIA notification within three months of commencement. Enhanced tier: designate a senior individual and start the compliance document.	Chief operating officer
This quarter	Run a joint exercise with head office on an attack nearby and a system outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Head of security

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for Martyn's Law?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Peak numbers counted for every site**
  Including staff, function rooms and outside areas.

- [ ] **Four procedures written for every site**
  Evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

- [ ] **A named duty manager on every shift**
  With authority to act at once.

- [ ] **Every staff member briefed on their role**
  Including seasonal, agency and night staff.

- [ ] **One alert reaches everyone on duty**
  With replies tracked and non-responders chased.

- [ ] **A way to reach guests in bedrooms**
  And in toilets, terraces and private rooms.

- [ ] **Outage procedures for bookings and payments**
  Tested on a real shift.

- [ ] **Ready to notify the SIA**
  And, for enhanced tier, a senior individual named.

PART 04

Rehearse and review.

Three scenarios to rehearse, a tabletop exercise for a late shift, a post-incident review template and the questions to ask.

01 Three scenarios

02 A tabletop exercise

03 Post-incident review

04 Questions for leaders

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse

CITY-CENTRE BAR AND NIGHTCLUB, 900 CAPACITY

01:00: a fight spills inside, then reports of a weapon outside

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Music still playing, doors open, and staff waiting for someone senior to decide.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Each section replies when secure; silent sections are chased by name within minutes.

WHO DECIDES

The duty manager declares lockdown; the door supervisor controls who comes in.

REHEARSE

A five-minute lockdown drill before opening.

HOTEL, 140 BEDROOMS AND A FUNCTION SUITE

21:30: a fire alarm during a 300-guest Christmas party

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Party guests returning for coats, drivers blocking the fire lane and bedrooms missed.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Area sweeps and the room list checked off at the assembly point.

WHO DECIDES

The duty manager runs the evacuation; the night manager owns the bedrooms.

REHEARSE

A walk-through with the events team and night porter.

RESTAURANT GROUP, 12 SITES

18:00 on the last Saturday before Christmas: bookings and payments fail at every site

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Each manager calls IT separately and sites get different instructions.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Every site acknowledges one instruction; head office sees who is trading.

WHO DECIDES

The head office incident lead decides on paper and cash; each manager runs their site.

REHEARSE

One site running on paper for an hour.

TABLETOP EXERCISE

Ninety minutes with the late shift

An illustrative exercise to run in a quiet afternoon slot. Read each inject aloud, give the room three minutes, and record the answers and the gaps.

DURATION	PARTICIPANTS	OBJECTIVE	FACILITATOR
90 minutes, including a 20-minute debrief	Duty managers, a supervisor, door team lead, reception and head office operations	Test the lockdown decision, reaching every member of staff and guest, and the handover to head office	Head of security, or an outside facilitator who does not take part

00:00	INJECT 1	Friday, 21:40. During a 300-guest Christmas party, a bar supervisor reports an unattended bag in the function suite cloakroom.	DISCUSS Who decides what happens next? What is the first instruction, on which channel, and who hears it?
00:15	INJECT 2	The duty manager moves guests out of the suite. The usual assembly point is next to the outside wall of the cloakroom.	DISCUSS Where do guests go instead? How do staff in other areas know the plan has changed?
00:30	INJECT 3	Twelve of 40 staff have not replied to the alert, including four agency staff and the night porter.	DISCUSS Who chases them, and how? Do we know their names and numbers tonight?
00:45	INJECT 4	Guests in bedrooms above the suite are calling reception, and a video of the evacuation is spreading online.	DISCUSS What do we tell guests in rooms? Who speaks for the venue, and what do staff post?
01:00	INJECT 5	Police confirm the bag is lost property. The party organiser asks to carry on.	DISCUSS Who decides to stand down? How is the stand-down sent, and what is recorded?
01:15	INJECT 6	Monday. Head office asks for a timeline of the first fifteen minutes.	DISCUSS Could we produce it from our records? What is missing, and who fixes it by when?

> Run it with the late shift as it really is, agency staff and new starters included. The answer "I would ring the general manager" is a finding: decide who acts without asking.

POST-INCIDENT REVIEW

Post-incident review template

Hold it within a week, with the people who were on shift. The aim is to fix the system, not to blame the person. Use the incident log and the actions tracker as the record.

INCIDENT	DATE	SEVERITY	REVIEW LEAD

01 What happened, and when

The timeline from the first report to stand-down, taken from the log, not from memory.

02 How we found out

Who spotted it, how it was reported and how long it took to reach the duty manager.

03 The decision

Who declared what, and when. Did anyone wait for permission they did not need?

04 Reaching staff

How many replied, how fast, and who was missed: agency, breaks, off-site, new starters.

05 Reaching guests

Bedrooms, toilets, terraces, other languages and guests who needed help.

06 Venues and head office

How other venues and head office heard, and any conflicting instructions.

07 People affected

Welfare of guests and staff, first aid given and the support offered afterwards.

08 Actions and checks

Each fix with one owner and a date, and how the next drill will prove it works.

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

THE DUTY

- ? Which of our sites are likely to be standard tier, which enhanced, and who is the responsible person for each?
- ? Could every site evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate tonight, and when was it last practised?
- ? Who on tonight's rota can declare a lockdown without asking anyone?

THE PEOPLE

- ? How long would it take to reach every member of staff on duty, and to know who had not replied?
- ? How would we reach guests in bedrooms, on terraces and in private dining rooms?
- ? Are our seasonal and agency staff briefed to the same standard as the regulars?

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Martyn's Law
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, named after Martyn Hett, who was killed at Manchester Arena.

Responsible person
The person or organisation in control of qualifying premises for the use that brings them into scope.

Standard tier
Premises where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected at the same time.

Enhanced tier
Premises where 800 or more people can reasonably be expected at the same time.

Public protection procedures
Actions staff can take if they suspect an attack: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

Public protection measures
Wider enhanced tier measures on monitoring, movement, physical security and information security.

Invacuation
Moving people away from danger to a safer place inside the premises.

Lockdown
Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving.

Reasonably practicable
Proportionate: weighing what a step achieves against its cost, time and difficulty.

Immediate vicinity
The area close to the premises. There is no fixed distance.

SIA
The Security Industry Authority, the regulator for Martyn's Law.

Senior individual
The person an organisation must designate for enhanced tier premises.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

When an attack happens outside a busy venue at 22:15, the alert is minute one. Protecting guests depends on every member of staff knowing their role, lockdown or invacuation starting at once, guests being told clearly, and a record of the first fifteen minutes.

WHERE INCIDENTS GO WRONG

01	**Fragmented information**	Different teams work from different information.
02	**Delayed decision making**	Leadership lacks visibility, so decisions wait.
03	**Uncoordinated response**	Several teams work independently on the same problem.
04	**Lack of visibility**	Critical actions become difficult to track.
05	**Lack of accountability**	Actions and decisions are poorly documented.

THE WHOLE INCIDENT, IN ONE PLATFORM



Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. It helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform.

THE PLATFORM

One connected platform, from first alert to final report.

Crises Control helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform. Each module does one job; the value comes from how they work together across the incident.

01 ESCALATE
SOS
Frontline staff report an incident in one touch from a mobile device.

02 START
Ping
Alerting and activation: reach people and collect acknowledgements and responses.

03 COORDINATE
Incident Manager
Activate the incident, assign roles, control communication and keep the timeline.

04 EXECUTE
Task Manager
Assign actions, track completion and escalate what stalls, with clear accountability.

05 OPERATE
Control Centre
Real-time view of incidents, timelines, task status and assets.

06 PROVE
Audit & Reporting
Incident records, response analysis and task accountability, ready to report.

07 ASSIST
CRAiG
AI assistant that helps users find information and work through the incident.

THE OUTCOMES

Alerting and activation
Reach the right people immediately.

Operational coordination
Structure communication and response activities.

Execution and visibility
Track tasks, responsibilities and progress.

Proof and accountability
Create a complete, defensible operational record.

Most organisations start with the capability they need today, often alerting, and expand as their requirements mature. Highlighted modules are the ones this playbook draws on.

HOW THE MODULES WORK TOGETHER

How the modules work together in a hospitality incident

The three-venue night in this playbook, from the first alarm to the review. Each step is an outcome, not a feature.

01	ESCALATE **SOS**	The door supervisor raises the alarm in one touch, with location, so the duty manager knows within seconds.
02	START **Ping**	Every member of staff on shift, agency staff included, gets the lockdown alert and replies when their area is safe.
03	COORDINATE **Incident Manager**	The duty manager activates the incident, assigns roles by area and keeps one log shared with head office.
04	EXECUTE **Task Manager**	Locking doors, sweeping toilets and terraces, reaching bedrooms and the head count become owned tasks that escalate if they stall.
05	OPERATE **Control Centre**	Head office sees every venue, areas secured, staff accounted for and decisions waiting, without phoning each site.
06	PROVE **Audit & Reporting**	A timestamped record of every alert, reply and decision is ready for the review, the insurer and the regulator.
07	ASSIST **CRAiG**	CRAiG helps the duty manager find information in the incident quickly, such as which areas have not confirmed they are secure.

COORDINATION
Everyone works from the same incident, roles and log.

VISIBILITY
Leaders see progress without chasing for updates.

EXECUTION
Every action has an owner, a deadline and an escalation.

ACCOUNTABILITY
The record of what happened builds itself as you go.

READINESS ASSESSMENT

How ready is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your hospitality organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 · ACTIVATION **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every member of staff on shift reached in seconds, including agency and new starters.	0 1 2 3
02 · ACTIVATION **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement from each area of the venue, with escalation when one stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 · COORDINATION **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One duty manager can start evacuation, invacuation or lockdown for the whole site.	0 1 2 3
04 · COORDINATION **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by the duty manager, security, head office and emergency services liaison.	0 1 2 3
05 · EXECUTION **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Public protection procedures under Martyn's Law run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 · EXECUTION **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of staff, areas secured and guests accounted for.	0 1 2 3
07 · ASSURANCE **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that shows what the venue did and when, for the regulator or an inquiry.	0 1 2 3
08 · ASSURANCE **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Shift-level drills, including the festive season and the busiest nights.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

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BOOK YOUR HOSPITALITY PLATFORM DEMONSTRATION

Watch a venue lockdown run end to end.

A live, 30-minute demonstration built around a hospitality incident. You will see one incident move through the whole platform, not a tour of features, and you can bring your own scenario.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE

01	SOS	A door supervisor raises a lockdown alert in one touch.
02	PING	Every member of staff on shift across the venue is alerted and acknowledges.
03	INCIDENT MANAGER	The duty manager activates the incident and assigns roles by area.
04	TASK MANAGER	Lockdown, guest communication and head count become owned tasks.
05	CONTROL CENTRE	Head office sees every venue, area secured and staff accounted for.
06	AUDIT & REPORTING	A timeline of the first fifteen minutes is produced.
07	CRAIG	CRAiG lists the areas that have not confirmed they are secure.

Book your demonstration →

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SCAN TO BOOK

COMPANION REPORT The protect duty